

HYDERABAD | Sleight of Hand

Prajarajyam Party (PRP) chief Chiranjeevi's plot to piggyback on the Congress for the 150-seat Greater Hyderabad Municipal Corporation has turned into a flop. The megastar's plans were torpedoed by Union Law Minister M. Veerappa Moily, who oversees Andhra Pradesh Congress affairs. Acolytes of Congress MP Y. S. Jaganmohan Reddy persuaded Moily to take a long-term perspective on the alliance. After the death of chief minister Y. S. Rajasekhara Reddy, support has swelled for the Congress and YSR's son Jaganmohan. "Where is the need for a tie-up when the Congress is very strong?" asked Agriculture Minister N. Raghuvveera Reddy.

The Assembly elections earlier this year proved that in the absence of an alliance, the PRP can chip away at the Congress' support base. This in turn will help the Telugu Desam Party, which has allied with the communists but kept the Telangana Rashtra Samiti out of its grand alliance this time. In a



CHIRANJEEVI'S POLITICAL CALCULATIONS HAVE GONE AWRY

face-saving measure, PRP leader C. Ramachandraiah said, "Internal squabbles in the Congress are causing inconvenience to us. That is why we dropped our earlier plan. Now we shall fight the poll alone." The megastar's shine seems to be waning offscreen. *by Amarnath K. Menon*

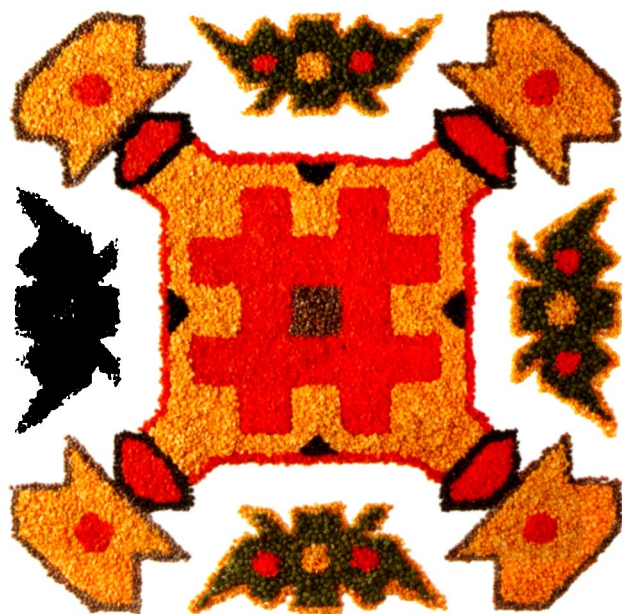
BHOPAL | Bird Game

The Madhya Pradesh Government's decision to scrap a bird sanctuary at Karera in Shivpuri district and another at Ghatigaon in Gwalior district has conservationists crying foul. They claim the move is a ruse to allow illegal sandstone mining in the districts. The denotification will ring the death knell for the Great Indian Bustard.

by Ambresh Mishra

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